

Skills Summary

Seeing How Many Without Counting

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Knowing a dot pattern at a glance

Rule: Some dot pictures have a shape you learn by heart: a pair, a slant of three, a square of four, a square with a middle dot. Say the number first; count only to check.

Example: How many dots? 

Step 1. The dots make a square with nothing in the middle — a shape I already know, so I name it instead of counting.

Step 2. The square shape is worth 4.

Try it: How many dots?  check: 3

Skill 2 — Reading a five-frame by its empty boxes

Rule: A five-frame is full at five, so read the *empty* boxes: dots = five – empty boxes.

Example: How many dots? 

Step 1. Two boxes are empty and a full frame is five — so I subtract instead of counting dots.

Step 2. $5 - 2 = 3$

Try it: How many dots?  check: 4

Skill 3 — Putting two small groups together

Rule: Name each little group at a glance, hold the bigger one in your head, and count on the smaller one: group + group = total.

Example: How many in all?  

Step 1. Each box is small enough to name on sight — a slant of three and a single — so I add the names.

Step 2. $3 + 1 = 4$

Try it: How many in all?   check: 5

Skill 4 — Deciding which picture shows more

Rule: Name *both* pictures, then compare the numbers. The symbol opens toward the larger one: $>$ is *greater than*, $<$ is *less than*. A wider card does not always hold more dots.

Example: A slanted card of three, or a full five-frame — which is more?

Step 1. Neither picture needs counting: a slant is three and a full frame is five, so I am just comparing two numbers I already know.

Step 2. The smaller number is on the left, so the symbol opens toward the frame: $3 < 5$

Try it: Left card: a single dot and a slant of three. Right card: a slant of three. Which is more? $<$